

Ken pow Seitan with asparagus

You may have heard of *kung pao* chicken in Chinese restaurants. Well, here's my vegetarian version. It's worth digging out the wok for this dish, but a large skillet will work. The more chiles you break open, the **hotter** Ken Pow will get.

IMPORTANT: You will use the Light Meat Seitan for this recipe. Make sure to eliminate the thyme, rosemary, and sage from the marinade.

½ recipe Light Meat Seitan (page 232; thyme, rosemary, and sage omitted from the seasoning paste), or Free-Range Roasted Seitan (page 240), cooked and cooled

2 tablespoons soy sauce

2 teaspoons mirin

2 teaspoons unrefined cane sugar

1 teaspoon toasted sesame oil

1 teaspoon vegetarian Worcestershire sauce

1 teaspoon black bean sauce

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

1 tablespoon arrowroot

1 tablespoon peanut oil

1 carrot, thinly sliced into diagonal half-moons

12 asparagus spears, cut into 1-inch [2.5-cm] slices

3 garlic cloves, minced

10 dried small red chiles (1 to 3 broken open)

½ red bell pepper, cut into ¾-inch [2-cm] squares

¼ cup unsalted roasted peanuts [35g]

6 scallions, thinly sliced

1 can (8 ounces) water chestnuts [250g]

1. **Cut** the seitan into ½-inch [1-cm] dice. Set aside.
2. In a small bowl, **combine** the soy sauce, sugar, sesame oil, Worcestershire sauce, black bean sauce, pepper, arrowroot, and ¼ cup [60ml] water. Mix well. Set the sauce aside.
3. In a hot wok or large heavy frying pan, **heat** the peanut oil over high heat. Add

the carrot and asparagus and cook, tossing with a spatula frequently, for about 1 minute. Pour in $\frac{1}{4}$ cup [60ml] water and let steam for another minute.

4. Add the seitan, garlic, and chiles and cook, tossing, for another 30 seconds or so. Add the bell pepper and peanuts and **stir-fry** for another 30 to 60 seconds, until the bell pepper has softened slightly. Give the sauce a stir and pour it into the wok. Toss with the spatula until the sauce thickens. Stir in the scallions and water chestnuts and toss once or twice. Serve at once.

SERVES 4

tip As with all stir-fry recipes, you must have everything prepped and ready to go before starting. I recommend serving a big bowl of sticky white rice alongside.

